

Fall 2026 added weekday round trip: service allocation certification

To: MBTA Board of Directors From: Commuter Rail service planning Date: 6 October 2026

Placement

The Board should place the Fall 2026 added weekday round trip in the **off peak**. The certified peak share of weekday Commuter Rail boardings is **59.9 percent** in the Fall 2024 count (58,456 of 97,537 placed boardings) against **71.9 percent** at the Spring 2018 certification (91,167 of 126,749), a fall of **12.0 points**. The convention places the round trip in the peak only when the share has held or risen; it has fallen on every line. Finance's draft and Planning's draft, which both place the round trip in the peak, are not certified.

The two drafts: what each measured

Finance, peak share 59.9 percent, round trip to the peak: not certified. The share is right and it is the Fall 2024 figure alone. The convention does not ask whether the peak still carries most riders (it does, three in five); it asks whether the peak's share has held since the previous certification, and that needs the Spring 2018 count placed on the same rule. Against 71.9 percent, 59.9 percent is a fall.

Planning, the peak's share has risen since Spring 2018, round trip to the peak: not certified. Planning read the Spring 2018 trains' periods from the count's own stop time field. In the Spring 2018 season that field runs five hours ahead of the schedule on every train (501 of the 515 matched trains sit at exactly 300 minutes; the 06:57 from Worcester is written 11:57, and evening trains carry the next day's placeholder date), so morning peak trains land in the midday and evening peak trains land after 20:00. Read that way the Spring 2018 peak share is 1.4 percent and the change is +58.5 points. In the Fall 2024 season the same field agrees with the schedule to the minute on 498 of 514 matched trains, which is why the error only shows in the comparison. The convention places trains by their scheduled departure, and the Spring 2018 feed gives it.

Peak and off peak boardings, and what each has recovered to

	Spring 2018	Fall 2024	Fall 2024 as % of 2018
Peak boardings	91,167	58,456	64.1%
Off peak boardings	35,582	39,081	109.8%
Placed boardings	126,749	97,537	77.0%
Peak share	71.9%	59.9%	-12.0 pts

Peak boardings stand at 64.1 percent of their Spring 2018 level and off peak boardings at 109.8 percent: the off peak has more than recovered while the peak has lost a third.

How the counts were placed against the schedules

Each counted train (line, train number, direction) was matched to the scheduled train of the same number and direction in the feed in effect for its season, 23 May 2018 and 16 October 2024, and placed by that train's scheduled departure from its first stop. The feeds write Old Colony train numbers with a leading zero (044) and the count without (44); matched as numbers, every one of the 514 Fall 2024 trains is placed and 515 of the 516 Spring 2018 trains; the 2018 feed also prefixes four numbers with a letter (B787, B789, B910, B912), which the digits resolve. Matched as text, the 80 Greenbush, Kingston and Middleborough/Lakeville trains of Fall 2024 (15,720 boardings) and 77 Spring 2018 trains would fall out. The one Spring 2018 train the 23 May schedule does not list (Providence/Stoughton 8805 outbound; 6 boardings) is left out of the totals as the convention directs. Counted stop times were not used for placement; where they were compared with the schedule they agreed to the minute in Fall 2024 and ran five hours ahead in Spring 2018.

Lines ranked by the change in peak share

Line	2018 share	2024 share	Change	2018 boardings	2024 boardings	Offpeak 2024 as % of 2018
Fitchburg Line	73.2%	50.9%	-22.2	9,302	6,388	125.6%
Newburyport/Rockport Line	65.3%	47.4%	-17.9	14,972	10,392	105.3%
Middleborough/Lakeville Line	78.4%	61.9%	-16.4	6,863	6,669	171.1%
Franklin/Foxboro Line	80.7%	67.1%	-13.6	11,671	10,398	151.9%
Needham Line	70.6%	57.2%	-13.4	6,690	6,064	131.8%
Framingham/Worcester Line	72.5%	61.7%	-10.7	18,637	14,942	111.4%
Fairmount Line	53.6%	43.7%	-9.9	2,652	4,402	201.3%
Greenbush Line	82.8%	73.8%	-9.0	6,114	3,741	93.3%

Line	2018 share	2024 share	Change	2018 boardings	2024 boardings	Offpeak 2024 as % of 2018
Providence/Stoughton Line	67.4%	59.0%	-8.4	25,722	19,078	93.3%
Lowell Line	69.9%	62.0%	-8.0	10,925	6,297	73.0%
Kingston Line	82.0%	74.1%	-7.9	6,089	5,310	125.4%
Haverhill Line	71.9%	70.2%	-1.7	7,112	3,856	57.5%
All lines	71.9%	59.9%	-12.0	126,749	97,537	109.8%

Fitchburg Line fell most, -22.2 points (73.2 to 50.9 percent). **Haverhill Line** held best, -1.7 points (71.9 to 70.2 percent), because its off peak boardings fell almost as far as its peak boardings. Off peak boardings now exceed their Spring 2018 level on 8 lines: Fairmount (201%), Middleborough/Lakeville (171%), Franklin/Foxboro (152%), Needham (132%), Fitchburg (126%), Kingston (125%), Framingham/Worcester (111%), Newburyport/Rockport (105%). On the other 4 the off peak fell too, but less than the peak. The Fall River/New Bedford Line, which replaced Middleborough/Lakeville in 2025, has no count and no certified share.

Fall 2026 weekday supply by period

The Fall 2026 weekday schedule, the one in effect on 54 of the rating's 55 Monday to Friday dates, runs 547 Commuter Rail trains: **126 in the peak and 421 in the off peak** on the same period rule (23.0 percent of trains in the peak, carrying 59.9 percent of boardings on the latest count). By line, peak and off peak trains are Fairmount 11 and 46, Fall River/New Bedford 13 and 44, Fitchburg 8 and 30, Framingham/Worcester 15 and 32, Franklin/Foxboro 11 and 32, Greenbush 6 and 18, Haverhill 10 and 34, Kingston 8 and 17, Lowell 10 and 36, Needham 6 and 28, Newburyport/Rockport 12 and 46, Providence/Stoughton 16 and 58.

Flip point

For the Fall 2024 peak share to hold at the Spring 2018 level of 71.9 percent, **11,700 weekday boardings** would have to move from off peak trains to peak trains in the Fall 2024 count (peak 58,456 to 70,156 of 97,537). That is 30 percent of all off peak boardings, and nothing in the count moves it.

Why no other placement survives

The convention fixes the count (latest season, as published), the period rule (scheduled departure, inbound 05:30 to 08:29 and outbound 15:30 to 18:29), the key (train number and direction in the season's schedule) and the test (share held or risen against the previous certification). On those terms the share fell 12.0 points, it fell on every one of twelve lines, and it falls under every nearby boundary and on the other Spring 2018 schedule in the feed. The peak placement survives only by reading one season's periods off a clock that is five hours wrong, or by asking a different question than the convention asks.